



AP

Cape Verde takes defending champion into extra time

Everyone loves an underdog. Even more so when it comes up against Argentina, the World Cup's favourite villain.

The Round of 32 clash was expected to be a routine outing for the defending champion, which had already scored eight goals in the group stage while conceding just one.

Lionel Messi had six goals by then, making him the all-time leading scorer in World Cup history. His seventh, which came late in the first half, was supposed to knock the wind out of Cape Verde's sails. Instead, the Africans came

roaring back after the break, with Deroy Duarte scoring the country's first-ever World Cup knockout goal. Vozinha, meanwhile, did his bit to keep Argentina at bay.

Cape Verde found the resolve to fight back a second time after Sindy Lopes Cabral curled a stunning long-range strike into the top corner in extra time to cancel out Lisandro Martinez's goal. He then produced one of the celebrations of the tournament, sprinting all the way into the stands to embrace his girlfriend.

Only in the 111th minute did Argentina finally find the winner and keep the debutant at bay.

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England survives the Azteca

Harry Kane's second-half brace inspired England to a 2-1 victory over DR Congo in the Round of 32, but a far sterner challenge awaited: Mexico at the Azteca Stadium.

The co-host enjoyed one of the most emotionally

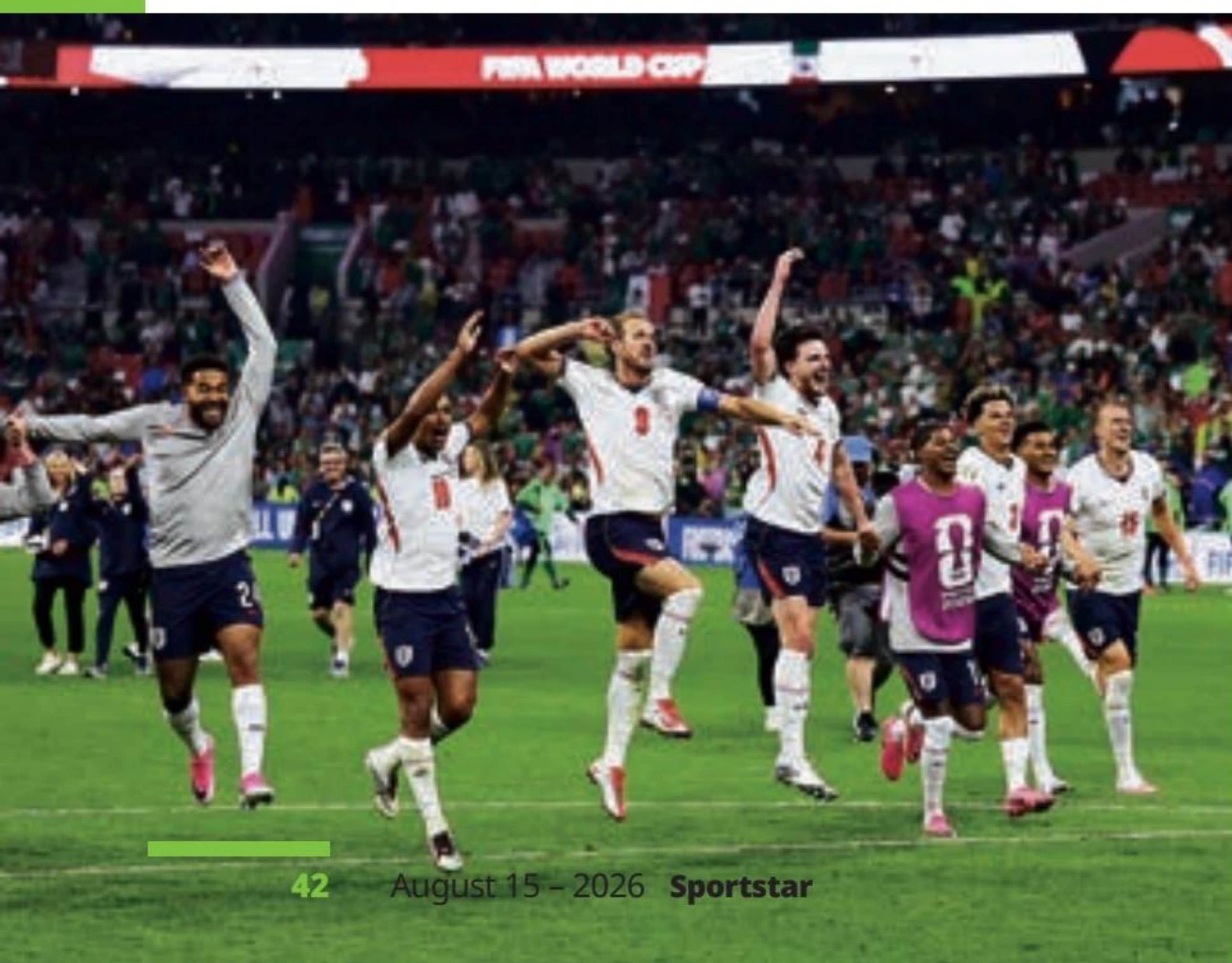
charged campaigns at the World Cup. That was evident when Raul Jimenez was left in tears after scoring against South Africa. At the Azteca, Mexico had a fortress, a stadium where it had lost just twice in 89 matches.

Jude Bellingham struck twice and Kane converted from the spot to give England a comfortable 3-1 lead. However, Jarrel Quansah's red card in the 54th minute, followed by Kane conceding a penalty 15 minutes later, left England defending a one-goal advantage with 10 men.

For 21 minutes, plus stoppage time, England withstood a hostile Azteca crowd and wave after wave of Mexican attacks to book its place in the quarterfinals.

Towering headers from Dan Burn and John Stones were central to the escape, underlining England's credentials as a team capable of grinding out results and mounting a genuine title challenge.

England eventually stumbled against Argentina in the semifinals but secured a third-place finish, its best performance since 1966.



REUTERS